

The BRIDGE IEP Meeting Guide

Running strength-based, family-centred planning meetings, where the 'I' in IEP stays genuinely individualised.

What This Guide Is For

An Individual Education Plan (IEP), sometimes called a Personalised Learning and Support Plan, ILP, or IFSP depending on your school and the child's age, is a written plan describing the individualised support a child with additional needs qualifies for. It's developed and reviewed by a team that includes the child's family and teachers, describes how the child is currently going, and sets measurable goals to help get them where they need to be.

This guide isn't about the paperwork. It's about running the meeting itself well, in a way that keeps the plan strength-based, keeps the family genuinely at the table, and keeps the 'Individual' in IEP meaningful rather than a checkbox.

The Strength-Based Foundation

The most important word in IEP is the first one. A plan only works when it's built around this specific child, not a template adjusted at the edges.

An IEP is both a process and a document, and it's most effective when it starts from the child's strengths and the family's vision, not from a list of deficits. Many of these students are used to hearing what they can't do until that becomes the whole story. A strength-based approach doesn't ignore the challenges. It just refuses to let them be the centre of it. Strengths and interests become the scaffold for the harder areas, aiming for early wins that build confidence and motivation for what's next.

Why this matters

A strength-based frame isn't a soft option. It's the difference between a plan the child and family can actually own, and one that's done to them.

Who's on the Team

An IEP must involve everyone responsible for caring for and teaching the child, not just the case manager. That typically includes:

- Parents and carers
- The child's classroom teacher(s), both general and specialist
- Any relief or support teachers involved regularly
- Paraprofessionals or teacher's aides delivering part of the program
- Where relevant, an interpreter: don't assume English is every family's first language

Two questions worth asking before every meeting: does this family need an interpreter, and will the child be spending significant one-on-one time with a teacher's aide who should also be in the room?

Before the Meeting

- ☐ Coordinate with school staff so everyone arrives prepared, not scrambling
- ☐ Pre-conference with parents ahead of time if anything difficult will be raised, so don't let them hear hard news for the first time in a room full of people
- ☐ Share evaluation results and data with the full team in advance so everyone's reviewed it, not reading it live
- ☐ Meet informally with parents beforehand where possible: welcome them, walk through the data, answer questions about the process
- ☐ Send a reminder ahead of the meeting

During the Meeting

- ☐ Introduce everyone and set a tone of mutual respect from the first minute
- ☐ Arrange seating that supports collaboration, not a 'family on one side, school on the other' layout

- ☐ Be alert to parents feeling outnumbered or intimidated. It's a common, understandable reaction in a room full of professionals
- ☐ Share a written agenda: purpose, intended outcome, and how you'll get there
- ☐ Make sure everyone understands their role, both in the meeting and afterwards

What the Plan Should Cover

A complete IEP typically includes:

- Present levels of academic and functional performance
- The child's eligibility or disability category, where applicable
- Measurable annual goals, both academic and functional
- Classroom and access considerations: seating, environment, anything that affects concentration or participation
- Accommodations or modifications for classroom work and assessments
- How and how often progress will be measured
- The frequency, location, and duration of any additional services

Closing the Meeting Well

- Give everyone a chance to contribute: the goal is shared ownership, not a plan delivered to the family
- Restate the agreed outcome clearly before anyone leaves, and correct any misunderstandings on the spot
- Check in on parents' understanding throughout, not just at the end
- Leave with a clear action plan: who is doing what, and by when
- End on a genuinely positive note: thank people for their time and their contribution

How This Ties to BRIDGE

This guide isn't a separate system from BRIDGE. It's what BRIDGE looks like inside a formal planning meeting:

	BRIDGE step	How it shows up in the IEP meeting
B	Behaviour Has a Reason	The strength-based lens keeps the meeting focused on why the child finds something hard, not just that they do.
R	Record the Pattern	Present levels of performance are the formal version of BRIDGE's R step: evidence before goal-setting.
I	Identify One Shared Goal	This is the heart of it: an IEP meeting is BRIDGE's I step formalised, with family and school arriving at shared, measurable goals together.
D	Design Matching Strategies	Accommodations and classroom strategies only work if they're consistent between the IEP and what happens day to day at home.
G	Give Consistent Language	The same goals, described the same way, prevent the plan from meaning one thing in the classroom and another at home.
E	Evaluate & Adjust Together	Scheduled reviews are BRIDGE's E step built into the IEP process by design, not left to chance.

MettleNest exists to make behaviour support practical, respectful, and within reach.

Connection • Collaboration • Communication